

“GOVERNMENT DOESN'T WORK ELECTION TO ELECTION”

Piyush Goyal, Union Minister of Commerce & Industry, decodes the government's policies



RAHUL KANWAL: The opposition says that the first 100 days of the Modi 3.0 government have been marked by U-turns. Your response?

40 | **A:** One thing that Prime Minister [Narendra Modi] has consistently followed... is that he's a leader who listens. He's a leader who's responsive to the needs of the times and the needs of the people. He has never shied away from being willing to change track but has always remained on the course to do what is best for the country. I don't think there has been any U-turn. If at all we allowed both options [for capital gains]—the indexation and long-term capital gains and the new simplified version of capital gains. It's only a reflection of a listening government that felt that nobody should be disadvantaged because of our actions. The [lateral entry] policy needed a little tweaking. In fact, when we introduced lateral entry, it was declared by the home ministry that it will respect all necessary government procurement principles. And therefore, we found that this needs to be corrected... I don't see any rollback.

RK: What are the big ideas of Modi 3.0?

A: The fact that we finally have political stability in the country and that PM Modi will get a chance to implement his vision for many more years to come has helped generate confidence across the world in the India story. They can now see India working hard at thrice the speed, [and with] three times more effort to get three times more outcomes and take India to developed nation [status] by 2047. And the fact that the milestones along the way are well-defined, well-planned... whether it's ease of living or ensuring a home for everybody; we've already given 40 million poor a free home, [and]

another 30 million homes are expected in the next five years. The fact that today nobody in the country stays hungry and India is fast becoming 100% self-reliant in food grain and foodstuff. The fact that we are one of the world leaders on sustainability and moving towards net zero... The fact that the country cares for the youth, supports start-ups, supports skill development and wants to make every young man and woman stand on their feet... We see the Indian rupee, [that is] not only stable but in a way showing strength. When [all] emerging markets are in distress, we see an economy where international trade is fast growing. More and more people are getting jobs in infrastructure-creation programmes to encourage electric vehicle (EV) mobility, adoption of EVs, solar power, taking our renewable energy from 200 GW to 500 GW by 2030... Hundreds and hundreds of decisions [were] taken in less than 100 days. Every Cabinet meeting makes game-changing rapid strides towards our dream to make India a developed nation, with an intermediate milestone: in this term, it will become the third-largest economy...

RK: One of the big decisions in the last 100 days was farmers being given more flexibility when it comes to export of products such as rice or onions. Was it done with an eye on Assembly elections, or is this a new policy direction?

A: Since 2014, I have personally been a part of meetings where the Prime Minister repeatedly tells us that 'any decision my government will take will always be based on what is good for the country, [for] the people's good and elections will never determine any of our decisions'. I once had a very important decision that